

Hello Jen,

I hope you'll excuse the unavoidable corniness that comes with written letters. Though the future is always uncertain, it is conceivable that Baltimore was the last place we'll see each other in person for quite some time. With my time at the lab nearing its end, I feel obliged to express to you what your mentorship and the work we've done together has meant to me. While this is mostly inspired by my own desire to make my gratitude known, I also want to leave no doubt in your mind about how extraordinary this experience has been for me.

You do not know this, as the boundaries of our professional relationship gave no opportunity to share it, but the years prior to entering the lab were extraordinarily difficult for me. I was navigating a personal tragedy involving the passing of a partner as well as heavy family caretaking responsibilities right as the pandemic was at its peak. So I did not have the expected early twenties experience, so to speak.

It isn't necessary to dwell on how things slowly improved from there. Suffice it to say that entering your lab was, to me, like the final stone needed to rebuild the fallen structures. I had dreamed for so long of working in science, living with the contradiction of believing in my own potential while feeling that life wasn't giving me an opportunity, and suddenly I was finally given a chance! When I was going through those dark times, I would have never, not in a million years, imagined that a few years later I'd be working at UPenn, publishing research, traveling to conferences, and meeting such incredible people. I would have laughed at anyone who suggested such a thing!

I know you are very aware of the academic impact your mentorship and the opportunities you've given me have had. But I don't think you know how much it meant for my life in general. Without knowing me, and without needing to, you gave me a chance, precisely the thing I needed the most. I've fallen in love with sleep science ever since, something I did not even know existed prior to knowing you, and it feels so good to finally have something I can call «my thing».

I want to thank you again for everything you've done for me, from this last trip to Philly and Baltimore all the way back to that initial email where you decided to give this random Argentinian guy an opportunity. I regret very much not realizing that the day of our presentations was the last day we'd see each other in person. I owed you a more proper goodbye and a more proper thank you, so I hope this letter can serve both purposes.

I hope you know that, no matter how many years go by, or where we are at any point in life, you will always be my mentor.

—Santi